

A Royal Game

T.S

Two assassins must survive the eccentric games of an erratic all-powerful being.

Dannt sighed as his colleague disposed of the bodies.

"We could have snuck by them to get into the castle."

Verona turned to face him. A white crescent mask covered the left side of her face. It was a stark contrast to her visible blackened and cracked cheek.

"You did not ... want to kill them?" Her voice grated in the night darkness.

It was their first mission together. Dannt had questioned his superiors why he had been assigned the bloodthirsty woman. Their response is they wanted someone to survive *him*.

It wasn't his fault that all his partners passed away.

Mostly.

"I'm not a pacifist if that's what you are asking. But killing creates unnecessary attention. Makes enemies."

"Then we ... kill them too." Verona pulled out a potion and uncorked it, washing her hands. The black water thickened red over her massive palms. They were like shovels, the sides somehow *sharp*, with a bright silver sheen.

Verona moved through the now unmanned gate to enter the courtyard of the castle. She was tall, her movements graceful as her black dress swirled dust behind her.

Dannt was forced to race after her. He himself barely made it to her hip, he had tried to compensate for his dwarven height with a large handlebar moustache.

They used the cover of darkness to advance forward. The castle was quite busy despite being almost midnight.

There was little time for the servants to prepare for the King's third marriage at the Midsommar festival.

Through the courtyard and over the cobblestone interior, they managed to reach the private chambers undetected. Before Verona turned the corner, Dannt stopped her with a raised hand, noticing the guards out in front.

"Listen. He may not be in his chambers. We need to get past the guards, unnoticed, and not leave a pile of entrails."

Verona stared at him. Her puckered face seemed to ripple, until she shrugged and turned aside.

Dannt reached into his pocket, bringing out a piece of metal. His hairy knuckles bent the rod to create a small critter. When he flicked it to the ground, it scuttered past the guards, distracting them so the pair could slip in.

And out.

No-one was there. Their target was missing.

"Is he in ... someone else's bed?" Verona rasped.

Dannt shook his head. It was a puzzle. He enjoyed a difficult mission.

"I don't doubt the man's promiscuity. But he is the King. He doesn't have to hide his sudden urge to grope the serving girl. If he wants to sleep around, he would do so in his own bed.

Maybe he is going for a midnight stroll. Come with me."

They traversed the strong, grey walls of the castle, hiding from guards and workers, when they reached the large, wooden doors of the throne room. Dannt looked closely and smiled. One of the doors was slightly ajar.

They stepped inside.

The hall was huge. A red carpet flowed down the middle of the chamber between wooden benches, leading to a golden throne on a pedestal of stone.

On the carpet, kneeling, was the King. He was facing away from the pair, hands on the ground in prayer. The flickering lamplights on the walls illuminated his crimson robes and golden crown.

Verona attacked in a flash.

"Wait..." Dannt cried, but it was too late. She bounded across the chamber with speed and her palm punched straight through the man's back.

The King didn't have time to scream. Verona lifted her forearm and moved to face Dannt, her outstretched arm had gone *straight through* the man's chest. Inside her hand was his still beating heart. She let it go, and it bounced onto the carpet, its red trail lost in the crimson.

Dannt sniffed. His new partner was beyond brutality. At least she seemed to get results.

Verona pulled her arm out of the most powerful man in the country.

The body fell and slid out of the robes, to reveal that it wasn't a man at all.

It was his little girl, Princess Felicia, pretending to be her father, her small figure disguised by the King's large robes. The twelve-year old's lips were puckered blue in death

The doors closed with a loud bang, as an unknown voice called out,

"You have spilt Royal Blood!"

Eery green fire shot around the room and the girl's body was sucked into the carpet, the fabric dragging her corpse away from sight.

The red cloth underneath Dannt's feet rippled, and he stumbled, barely managing to keep his feet. The carpet began moving as if its fabric was affected by the tide; red waves began crashing down onto Dannt. He jumped over them, but saw Verona being swept towards him, her back leaning on a tidal wave. She collided with him, and they screamed together, sucked down into the red.

Dannt felt the dry material on his tongue and coughed; when the ground stopped moving, he untangled himself from Verona and stood up. The carpet he stood on now surrounded him; he was in a scarlet hallway, the walls, roof and floor bright red. Green fire sparked and danced around him. The corridor was endless, Dannt could see incredibly far in the distance. He shivered when he looked backwards. A black maw yawned at him, the deep darkness unnaturally close. He quickly decided that he would not venture backwards under any circumstances.

Turning back around, Dannt yelped. The red carpet was moving, as something formed out of the red.

It was a ghoul. Skeletal hands and feet poked out of a full body cloak made from green fire. Blackness swirled underneath its hood, the two blazing blue fires in the gloom could only be its eyes.

Again, Verona acted on instinct. Her giant hand sliced through the spectre. It simply passed through; the ghoul did not react.

It hovered up in the air and began speaking, its voice light and feminine.

"I'm disappointed. I never thought I would be summoned to an empty throne room at the dead of night. I always hoped that the death of a royal would be a ceremonious affair, full of people. Who could watch judgement be done."

Dannt was stunned but began talking quickly. Information was always key to survival.

"Good day to you sir. May I ask why you have been summoned?"

The Ghoul did a little twirl in the air.

"An ancient spell. To avenge the death of one with royal blood."

The late Princess Felicia had been renowned as the King's true treasure. The King wouldn't raise an eyebrow if someone made an obscene joke about his Queens, but more than one head had been removed for even frowning at the Princess.

Killing her had been an incredible mistake. It made Dannt feel alive.

"So then. Why are we still alive? Why aren't you ... avenging?"

The ghoul *giggled*. A ghoul was a creature out of the most abhorrent horror stories. They were basically invincible, able to bend time and space around them on a whim. Their affliction for malevolence was not a favourable blend with omnipotence.

Dannt didn't know how one had been trapped here, let alone why its purpose was to aid the royal bloodline.

"It has been centuries. Wait, no. I had never seen the throne room before. It could be millennium since I have been released.

It means I want to take my time to play!"

The fire on the walls burned bright.

"What do you want?" Dannt asked.

The ghoul tapped a finger on the side of its hood.

"Let's begin with some names. Those who play my game need names!

I am the Terrifying Hand of Royal Judgement! Or Terry for short. What about you two? Who are you?"

Dannt shrugged.

"Oh us. We're nobody. Just happened to be walking by."

"Of course! You two are super innocent! Just happened to be in the area! You are funny! You have to tell me your names though, I will get them but if you make me ask again you might not enjoy it."

Dannt and Verona responded quickly.

"Great, let's play!"

Terry clapped. The way forward brightened with green light, and symbols etched themselves onto the floor. Dannt couldn't make them out but could see that there were at least four separate ones over the course of the hallway.

"It's very simple. Just make it to the end! Good luck!"

Verona stepped forward with a rasp.

"Once ... there is a loser, will the other ... go free?"

Terry did a spin in the air.

"Hmmm, maybe!"

Verona nodded and swung a hand at Dannt's neck. Just before his windpipe was crushed, he was teleported away, appearing behind his companion. The ghoul's power was incredible.

"It won't be that easy! You must play." Terry crossed its arms.

"Really Verona? Off a *maybe*?" Dannt stared at her.

She shrugged.

"PLAY!" Terry yelled.

"Wait just one second." Dannt replied. Behind a held hand, he whispered,

"I think the ghoul has been corrupted by the mind of the child it's 'avenging'."

"I said PLAY!" This time it squealed.

"We need to strategize!" Dannt rebuked. "We need the time, otherwise we won't play the game as well!"

"Ughh," it moaned. "Fine. You have one minute."

"As I was saying. By being summoned, I believe the ghoul has been influenced by the mind of the child you killed, hence the game."

"Does that ... mean it is ... harmless?" Verona grunted.

"Oh, gods no. It is a spectre raised through spilt blood. It will kill us or at least try to. I think there is a way to survive, you just need to follow my lead."

"Oh, and Verona?" Dannt mentioned when she had taken a step past him.

"I'm much more useful to you alive. Don't try and kill me on a whim, and I will get you out of here."

She looked at him.

"I have ... heard. Everyone with you ... still alive?"

Dannt bowed his head. He had seen beheadings, torture, drownings. So many of his companions had screamed when they were sent to the land beyond. People behind his back talked about his curse.

What they didn't know was that it wasn't true.

"I don't kill them. I just know how to survive when they don't.

Always.

I'm telling you now, because no one listens.

It's smarter to follow me through the fire, you're less likely to burn alive."

Verona trailed a hand down her the blackened side of her face.

"We ... shall ... see.

We are ... ready." She hissed at the ghoul.

"Yes!" It shot up into the air, it's two hands moving in a wave. "Just start walking forward!"

They followed its instructions. Down the corridor, they came across the first symbol. Emboldened in green fire, it was a backwards E, the lines curving into small thorns at the end.

"Go on, step on it."

Nervously, they did so. Terry flew through one red wall, to appear out the other.

"Let's go! I call this, Save the Dame!"

Dannt opened his eyes after the flash of green light. The symbol has disappeared. In its place stood two large beasts. They were emerald, boars with green spikes all over their muscular bodies. Behind them, was a figure of some sort. Dannt was unable to make it out as the boars charged, roaring as their muscles flexed. Verona screeched in reply, slamming her foot to the ground with power. The carpeted floor rippled, sending a wave hurtling towards the monsters.

They toppled, and within seconds, Verona had jogged forward, crushing their heads with her hands. Their spikes bounced off her fingers, making a metallic screeching sound. Dannt pushed past her to see the figure wave at them, a sharp smile protruding out of her grey face before she evaporated into dust along with the boars' corpses.

Terry did a jig.

"Congratulations, that was an easy one. Onwards!" It's shoulder and arm transformed into an arrow, and it shot forward with remarkable speed in that direction.

The next symbol was an upside-down A, a myriad of lines crisscrossing over the hole in the letter.

After the green light flashed them again, they noticed what had replaced the symbol.

The walls were now wooden, handles at waist height. When Dannt turned it, the door opened, revealing that inside were ... clothes.

"Fashion Show!" Terry giggled.

Dannt grimaced, he was beginning to be more than just irked at the noise. Trying to distract himself, he noticed Verona looking stricken.

"You alright? It's just clothes Verona, it'll be good. Bring some life out of you!"

She returned his gaze, lifting a hand to the uncovered side of her blackened face.

"Haven't dressed ... since we all ... the fire that took ..." She trailed off, her eyes far away. Dannt had only seen her with murderous intent or complete apathy. Not this.

He clicked his fingers to distract her.

"Hey, I've solved it, I get the game, *I know how to win*. Come, get dressed, I'll put you in something that'll make you look like a proper clown!"

Verona turned a murderous glint on him, making him feel more comfortable.

After a few minutes in the wardrobes, they stepped back out into the hallway. The ghoul hovered in the air, hands on top of its eyes as it counted down.

"Three ... two ... one...Ready!" It pulled its hands away with a flourish.

Verona's change was astonishing. She had traded her dark black cowl for a summer yellow dress, white frocks lining the hem, collar and sleeves. The crescent mask had disappeared, revealing a sharp, unblemished face, fixed with an almond eye. The blackened, cracked side was covered with wisps of white paint, lessening its startling appearance.

Verona cringed as Terry flew down, stopping within a hairpin in front of her.

"Wow! You look amazing! You smell like the fields, where we can play with the animals and eat berries and pick flowers and ... wow, jut wow! Can we go to the fields, please!"

The barrage made Verona take a small step backwards, until she squeezed out an answer.

"...Soon."

The ghoul turned its attention to Dannt. A royal fur coat sat across his shoulders, red with a white and black polka dot pattern on the collar. Lifts in his black dress shoes brought him up to a somewhat more reasonable height. Along with the tacky golden crown on his head, a deep bronze amulet sat across his nape. It hid the device on his neck, which had sharp extensions that pierced through his skin.

"Hello child. Do we pass your test?"

His voice was much deeper, regal some might say.

The ghoul didn't respond immediately. Instead of erratically flying, it came closer to the ground. The raw bones that were its hands and feet seemed to morph, a layer of pink skin infusing themselves onto the skeletal features. Underneath the hood, the blue fires dimmed and began transitioning every now and then into pupils. Dannt could even begin to make out a nose, and some red lips.

"Oh, umm," it stumbled. "Yes! Full marks for her."

"And I child?" Dannt questioned.

Terry bowed its head then turned away.

"Onto the next!"

While it still hovered just off the ground, instead of flying away in the air, the ghoul seemed to skip forward, its arms moving merrily from side to side.

The pair followed and reached the third symbol. While the red hallway seemed infinite, Dannt couldn't see any discrepancies after the fourth symbol. They were halfway through.

There was no hesitation when they stepped onto the green badge, a warped amalgamation of an S and V, the S twisting around its counterpart.

Dannt thought he saw the letter moving, *squeezing* the V.

After a green flash, the hallway began to transform, and suddenly they were back in the throne room. The windows were open, letting fresh sunlight naturally brighten the large chamber. The ghoul sat on the golden throne, a black twisted crown resting on its head. The body of the Princess was nowhere in sight.

"The King's Judgement!" Terry yelled. It slammed a fist on the armrest. Hundreds of people appeared in the throne room, some stood around the sides while others sat on the benches behind Dannt and Verona, who were in front of the ghoul.

The spectators cheered at the announcement. When Dannt stared at one, he saw that the person was translucent, the ends of their body seeping upwards into a mist.

"You have both been found guilty of murder!"

The crowd shunned them loudly.

"The King's ruling is law, but with judgement, comes mercy. One of you must answer for your crimes. Who will be struck down? I will let you decide!"

The crowd cheered as Verona turned slowly towards Dannt, her bludgeon-like hands moving menacingly.

He pointed a finger at her.

"What did I tell you? You better bloody listen." He ordered.

Verona put her hands down without complaint.

"Thank you." Dannt replied calmly. He ignored the sweat leaking down the back of his neck and turned towards the ghoul.

"Oh, my Princess. You must not separate us!"

The ghoul stared at him. Its hood morphed, and the face of a child flickered into existence.

The crowd's noise dimmed.

"I don't understand. I ... I think you should fight." Terry whispered, although it was beginning to look more like Felicia, the dead Princess.

"Oh, my sweet child. I always fight with my wives. You don't want that. You want a mother don't you? A mother and a father, to be with you always."

"I want ..." She, as the ghoul was no longer an 'it', nervously tugged at one of her grey pigtails. It blossomed with golden colour at the touch.

"What do you want my sweet child?" Dannt took a step forward, sweeping his regal cloak behind him and taking off his crown in a practiced manner.

"Say something sweet to her." He whispered to Verona. She made no response.

"Did you not hear me Verona? Say something special to the Princess."

Was it something to do with being short? Why did they never listen? He had watched his brother venture out into the waves and be swept out of his life. He still felt guilty, despite yelling his protests at the time. Dannt should have done something more. He needed to take ownership, to lead those he cared about to safety.

The time was now.

“Do you want to get out of here Verona? Alive?”

You can try lop its head off, like what you did before.

You can lop *my* head off.

Or you can do what I say and *fucking* say something sweet.”

Verona cracked her neck.

And spoke gently.

“Please ... daughter. Let ... mama live.”

The ghoul stared at her, then turned back to Dannt who had narrowed the gap between him and the throne to only a metre. He got on his knees.

“Sweet child. We will always be here for you. Together. Isn’t that what you want?”

Dannt held out a hand. The ghoul stepped forward, placing a tiny human palm in his. The fingernails were pink and freckled with silver stars.

“I...” Her blue eyes brightened, and the young girl smiled a white grin full of teeth.

“You both survive. On to the next.”

The throne room reverberated, transforming back into the red hallway. The girl skipped forward, whistling a tune as Dannt followed.

He turned to back to Verona.

“See. Just trust me. I can get us through this.”

He held out a hand. After a second’s hesitation she grasped it. Dannt felt her power, the strength in the shovels that she called hands. Here was someone who could take him anywhere in the world. To a life full of danger. He just had to lead her through it.

They moved to the final symbol. It was simply a T that was sideways, nothing was moving or growing on it.

Dannt closed his eyes in preparation of the flash, letting the black fill with green. When he opened them, he saw that the floor in front had begun moving. A large crack appeared in the ground, and with a rumble, the carpet began splitting in two. The rug pulled away, leaving an expanse. Above the emptiness, a waterfall of magma flowed down from the roof, the heat smashing into Dannt’s face with force, the liquid foaming white froth. Dannt

stepped forward to look down. A lengthy drop led to dark, sharp points of earth, huge stalagmites rising out of a sea of bubbling lava.

He quickly stepped back.

"Ah. What exactly is that my child?" He asked.

"Simple. It's your way out of here."

Felicia, no, Terry floated upwards. The hood had reappeared, and the blackness inside could not be dispersed by the bright magma light.

"I don't believe you. That is not the way out."

It shrugged.

"Stay here then. Enjoy my company. I am eternal. I can wait. And you will starve. Maybe you will eat one another, I'm sure the lava can be used as a makeshift cookfire if you are resourceful enough. I wouldn't be surprised if you tried flesh raw though. Those on the verge of dying sometimes can't really wait for a spit can they?"

The ghoul's bloodcurdling words were quickfire, flabbergasting Dannt.

"You can't seriously expect ..."

"I do not care!" It thundered. Its voice became demented as it rose higher in the air. The blue fires Dannt had first spied in its hood were now red and burning fiercely. Dannt looked at them closely, he thought he could hear the screams of the damned. He tried to look away but couldn't, he was being pulled forward, the bonfires were growing larger, he could see burnt humans with the skin and claws of monsters dancing around them, beckoning him forward with jagged smiles as they screamed and screamed, the noise piercing, their claws coming closer to his face ...

He was yanked backwards, crashing bodily onto the carpet. He blinked, then looked up to see Verona covering his entire vision with her face and body.

"Don't ... look."

He nodded with fear. Dannt doubted he could forget those wide smiles. The way they screamed would stay with him until the end of his days.

Dannt rose to his feet. The ghoul remained in the air, its arms crossed in satisfaction.

"I repeat. You're only way forward is down there. There is no escape, no second chances, this is the end of the line."

"There is nothing we can do?" Dannt asked, pointedly avoiding its eyes. It shrugged.

"Surviving the last trial was smart. I was only expecting there to be one of you for this last stage. No matter. When you are ready, please."

It motioned with a hand.

"Jump. Maybe you will even survive."

It's laughter drove spikes of fear in Dannt's chest. He began to look at the ghoul's hood, then instinctively jerked his head back to Verona. She was staring at him.

"What do ... we do?" She asked.

He didn't respond, trapped in the madness of his memory.

"Dannt!" The sound of his own name, spoken for the first time in such stunted dialect, shook him out of his reprieve.

Life or death situations. Trapped with no way out. It was always exhilarating.

Dannt smiled and strode forward, looking at the lava pit.

"So. You are saying that we have to jump down there correct? There is no way backwards and this waterfall is preventing any way across."

The ghoul ran a bony hand through the cascading water in boredom.

"That's about the thick of things."

"And it leads to certain death?" Dannt replied.

"I never said anything of the sort. In fact, I was very clear that you *might* survive."

Dannt looked down at the bubbling lava and jagged rocks, then back at the ghoul.

"There's always a possibility."

Dannt couldn't see anything in the blackness of its hood, but he was sure that it was smiling.

"Right. And just to confirm. This 'not so certain' certain death is our punishment for killing the Princess Felicia?"

The ghoul's voice rose.

"Killed? You cold-bloodedly ripped out the heart of a young girl who wasn't even aware of your presence."

"Look, I can understand you might question our morals. But, have you wondered whether there could be a different path?" Dannt asked. Terry stared coolly at him.

"You will not be released. You killed a member of the Royal Bloodline."

"Thank you for reminding me. I am not asking to be released. What I'm saying is, what if the girl isn't dead?"

The ghoul hesitated for a split second, before sneering at Dannt.

"Nonsense. I am only summoned by death."

"Be that as it may, death is not irreversible. What if she could be revived?"

"You are beginning to test my patience dwarf."

Dannt raised his hands.

“Let’s not get personal here. Not to mention that you said you were *more* than happy to wait here before we took the plunge, so let’s have a chat. Do you not know that people have come back from death?

People have drowned with no pulse and coughed up water to survive.

Some can seemingly pass from a sickness in bed, until a miracle breathes life into them, so they are eating at the dinner table that night.

I’ve once seen a head be chopped off, and as it rolls it gapes and blinks at its own headless body.”

“Have they returned, alive, after the decapitation?” The ghoul interrupted.

“Maybe if you stuck the head back onto the neck. No-one doing the lopping ever seems eager to try so I’ve never seen my hypothesis trialled.

But I hope you understand my point. And I’m talking about natural revivals, what happens when you introduce magic? It can change the game.

The Princess might be a little girl, but she shares something in common with all other people.

We will do whatever it takes to survive.”

“You ripped her fucking heart out!” It screamed, edging forward in anger.

“Yet her heart is still beating! Why would it stop?” Instead of retreating at the ghoul’s antagonism, Dannt stepped forward, lowering his voice.

“Think about what happened, slowly. The girl *may* have died, and you got summoned. What did you do?

You put up the cage, transported us into the carpet, only two or three seconds after Verona attacked. I saw the torch lights as you did so, the ones on the throne room’s wall. Normally the fire would flicker and crackle. Before you put us into the carpet, *they stopped moving*. You’ve got us in a bottle outside of time. Probably to stop an angry monarch or his guards from interrupting your little game.

What does that mean? It means you could still save her!”

Dannt kept his face smooth as he spoke. All that mattered was what the ghoul believed.

He had no idea if the torches had stopped.

Terry floated down. Again, it’s human features began to reappear, starting at the hands and feet, then the face. They only materialised for moments, swapping between skin and the ghoul’s white bones.

Dannt continued.

"Come child. Save her. Be the hero, the knight in shining armour that saves the princess. The one Princess Felicia dreams of every night."

"But ... but ..." It ... her voice dropped to a squeak. "You killed ..."

"A necessary evil to save her! Go on child. We want to free you; you do not need to be the carrier of vengeance. Forego your justice and save her!"

The girl looked at him with one bright blue eye. The other was a fierce red blaze. One side of her red lips curled, revealing jagged white spikes.

"I WILL..." The ghoul roared.

"SAVE HER!" The girl finished.

Blinding white light flashed Dannt. He fell on his backside, his vision black.

When he could see again, he noticed a young girl, golden pigtails wrapped in pink ribbons waving at him.

She grabbed his hand, then went to Verona, grabbing hers as well.

"Now, Daddy, Mummy. How do we save her?"

Dannt realised they were still wearing their court clothes.

"You need to bring us back to the throne room. But don't start time! First, we need to have a look. Can you do that?"

"Of course." She replied, then waved a hand. The large red corridor melted away in a collection of colourful sparks. They were back in the throne room. The Princess lay on the carpet, blood stains drenched the cobblestones next to her. It looked ... dry. Dannt swallowed, saying nothing. Green flames were still burning on the sides of the chamber.

They weren't out of this yet.

The girl's heart was lying on the ground in front of her bloodied chest.

Thank god Verona hadn't squeezed it into mush.

"Do you see that child? You need to put the heart back in to save her."

The girl moved next to the princess. The ghoul's transformation was complete. They looked the exact same.

"She's so cold. I think she is gone. Please don't let her be gone!"

Dannt knelt next to the body, grabbing the girl's hand. For a second, the skin vanished, the white bones making sweat bead his forehead.

"Cup your hand over the heart child. Good. Now, on three, you are going to start time and put it back to where it belongs.

Ready?

One.

Two.

THREE!"

Dannt heard an abnormal, metallic screech as the scene started again. The ghoul immediately moved the heart into the Princess and *got sucked inside her body*. Dannt turned, to see the green flames had disappeared.

"Go!" He yelled at Verona. She needed no encouragement. Together, they sprinted to the doors. Only for it to open in their faces, as the King and dozens of royal guards stepped inside.

"Who are you?" the King snarled, wielding a large sword with a golden pommel.

"Ahhh," Verona stepped back.

"Guessing time has stopped may have been incorrect." Dannt said to himself.

The King's eyes widened and Dannt turned to stare backwards.

In horror.

The Princess was standing. To say that she was alive would be a hasty judgement.

Half of her body was normal, golden pigtail and curls nestling over a blue eye. Her other half was a ghastly apparition. Her skin was a deep grey, head bald with tufts of hair splayed in places. Black, chapped lips met halfway with the Princess' usual rosy smile. Her bad leg was disjointed and dragged behind her as she moved forward.

The foot was bent completely the wrong way and she stood on it in a way that made Dannt's skin recoil. Her arm was split down the middle, her pinky and ring finger separated by a rotten crevasse that lined down the rest of her forearm.

"What ... my little girl?" The King moved past Dannt and Verona, trembling as he met his daughter.

"Daddy?" The thing's voice started sweet and ended in a throaty gargle. The King fell to his knees crying.

"You ... you ... you abomination!" With a scream, he raised his great sword and cleaved the Princess in two. Silence.

Then a sound.

"You have spilt Royal Blood!"

In the blink of an eye, the King disappeared, leaving his crown spinning on the ground.

"It's over." Dannt relaxed.

"No." Verona replied. He turned to see the new danger. Dozens of guards raised their weapons at him.

Verona stepped in front of him, her hands growing into shovels, the bladed sides glistening.

Dannt smiled at his companion. For the first time ever, it looked like one of his companions would survive him.

The curse was over!

Watching her charge at the guards made Dannt realise something however.

It seemed when he was involved, there was always a large butchers bill to be paid.

The End